

Beyond Adaptation: an LLM-Supported Self-Presentation Ideation Tool for Cross-Cultural Mingling

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Abstract

Cross-cultural mingling events create social bonding and cultural exchange but challenge participants, particularly those from collectivist cultures, in expressing individuality and building connections. Existing tools focus on adaptation to external norms but ignore the empowerment of self-presentation. Through in-depth interviews with participants experienced in mingling events, we identified key purposes, challenges, and strategies. Findings reveal the importance of distinct, memorable characteristics for fostering connections, addressing common struggles with being remembered, or forming deeper bonds. To address these needs, we proposed an LLM-supported self-presentation ideation tool that helps users uncover, refine, and amplify their characteristics through unstructured inputs and visualizations. This work supports active participation and promotion in diverse mingling contexts.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → **Interface design prototyping**; **Empirical studies in collaborative and social computing**;

Keywords

Cross-Cultural, Mingle, Self-Presentation, LLM, Memorable Characteristic, Ideation

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1 Introduction

Mingling events are social gatherings that allow movement and interaction in open spaces and are sometimes called free-standing social interactions or unstructured social gatherings [4]. The purpose of them is to create casual connections, as they allow participants to approach and talk with others freely, even strangers, through

focused conversations[10]. Mingling events could create opportunities for social bonding, cultural exchange, and professional networking [9, 16].

Mingling events are primarily based on small talk, often described as “talk for the sake of talking” or “phatic communion” [14, 22]. Small talk focuses on connection rather than deep information exchange and can be divided roughly into (1) greeting, (2) approaching, (3) centering, and (4) leave-taking [21], with the centering phase being the most critical part of any small talk. This phase often alternates between brief, interactive exchanges (chat phases) and longer, narrative-driven interactions (chunk phases) [7].

1.1 Barriers in Cross-Cultural Interaction

Mingling events very often take place in cross-cultural scenarios, where people may experience common problems in any cross-cultural encounter.

In addition to the frequent barrier of lack of language proficiency, which often leads to misunderstanding [1], cultural background and values may also create challenges. For instance, those with a collectivist cultural background, where group harmony and the mindset of “fitting in” rather than “standing out” are stressed, may have trouble adapting to individualistic environments where one’s unique characteristics are highlighted or even celebrated [20]. The collectivist norms, which emphasize harmony and indirect communication, make self-promotion and sharing of ideas difficult for them [5].

In situations like this, it is natural for participants of the mingling events to socialize with people with similar cultural background, sometimes referred to as the similarity attraction effect [3, 13], or with those who they have known previously. While natural in nature, relying on culturally familiar networks, however, may hinder greater participation and increase feelings of isolation [2].

1.2 Existing Tools and Approaches for Cross-Cultural Adaptation

Traditional tools for cross-cultural adaptation aim to help identify cultural differences. For instance, cultural assimilators [8] provide scenario-based training to explain behaviors in foreign settings. Although these tools are useful for fostering foundational knowledge, they often lack the flexibility required for real-time adaptability during dynamic social interactions such as mingling events.

Recently, large language models (LLMs) have been viewed as useful tools for supporting cultural and social training. These kinds of systems focus on creating personalized conversational agents

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with different personalities and backgrounds, providing users with a safer environment to practice social interaction [12, 18].

However, both traditional tools and LLM-supported systems highly focus on learning external norms and adapting to them, while ignoring users' ability to showcase their individuality in social settings. This leaves a gap in empowering users to take an active role in shaping how they presented themselves during interaction.

1.3 Theoretical Background: Self-Presentation and Impression Management

Classical theories of self-presentation [11] emphasize the construction of a "personal front"—the set of visible markers such as clothing, facial expressions, and overall demeanor that signal a person's expected role. However, constructing a personal image can lead to two outcomes: on the one hand, individuals might be persuaded by the performance they deliver; on the other hand, they may eventually recognize that the image they have built is merely an façade used instrumentally rather than a sincere reflection of the self.

Traditional and digital self-presentation tools, such as manuals [17] and video feedback systems [19], have been used to help people craft a polished public persona. However, these tools may also risk misalignment with one's authentic self if the focus remains solely on external markers. For example, strategies that emphasize achievements to gain respect can inadvertently reduce perceptions of warmth—a phenomenon sometimes referred to as the "self-promotion paradox" [15]. Recognizing these challenges, our work leverages the creative capabilities of LLMs to reconcile the need for a polished public image with genuine self-expression in an implicit way, particularly in cross-cultural settings.

1.4 Contribution

This work makes two primary contributions:

- (1) **Empirical Insights:** Through in-depth interviews with participants who have attended cross-cultural mingling events, we identify the purpose, challenges, and strategies used in cross-cultural mingling events.
- (2) **Design Prototype:** We propose the prototype of an LLM-supported self-presentation ideation tool that allows users to ideate and amplify their characteristics. The tool allows users to extract their characteristics through unstructured descriptions and to combine and visualize these characteristics.

2 An In-depth Interview Study of the Cross-cultural Mingling Events

To explore participants' experiences in cross-cultural mingling events and identify design opportunities for an LLM-supported tool, we conducted in-depth, semi-structured interviews to identify the potential challenges.

2.1 Procedure and Participants

We recruited seven participants for the interviews from a cross-cultural communication course in a large public university in Taiwan and through snowball sampling. Each participant received 200 TWD (approximately \$6) for their time. Participants were aged

Table 1: Frequency of Special Characters

	Gender	Education	Nationalities
P01	Male	Undergraduate	Taiwan
P02	Female	Master	Taiwan
P03	Female	Undergraduate	Mexico
P04	Female	Undergraduate	Taiwan
P05	Female	Master	Taiwan
P06	Female	Undergraduate	Czech Republic
P07	Male	Master	Taiwan

between 19 and 26 years old, and all of them had prior experience in at least one cross-cultural mingling event. The interviews were conducted either face-to-face ($n = 4$) or online ($n = 3$). Table 1 summarizes their demographics.

The interviews were audio-recorded, transcribed, anonymized, and analyzed using Atlas.ti Cloud Service. Open coding identified initial findings, which were refined and merged. Axial coding then structured these into higher-order categories, revealing relationships and insights.

2.2 Interview Protocol

Before the interview, participants were informed of the research purpose, assured of confidentiality, and consented to recording. They were then briefed on mingling events as informal gatherings without specific agendas, where attendees could freely move and interact.

The interview focused on participants' experiences with cross-cultural mingling events in three areas. Participants first reflected on past experiences of participating in cross-cultural mingling events and were asked to describe the settings, backgrounds of attendees, and their general impressions. They then detailed their most memorable mingling experience, including entry, navigation, exit strategies, and overall feelings. Finally, they shared their preparation methods and adjustments based on prior experiences.

3 Results

We divided the results into three sections: the purpose of participation, the difficulties encountered during mingling events, and the strategies that participants have employed in these settings. Due to space limitations, only a selection of the findings is presented in this section.

3.1 Purpose of participation

We categorized participants' purposes into the fulfillment of four needs: emotional need, future-oriented need, informational need, and participation without a specific purpose. The first two reflect long-term, non-immediate goals, while the rest focus on immediate benefits or lack a defined purpose.

3.1.1 Emotional Need.

Emotional needs refer to a desire to form a group of close acquaintances. We found that connecting with people who share

similar characteristics, such as having studied in the same city before, reduces isolation in foreign environments. Besides, negative experiences like exclusion could also motivate participation.

Emotional needs sometimes stem from a desire, where feeling included can lead to increased participation in group activities, thereby enhancing skills and confidence.

If I feel a sense of belonging here, I'll be more willing to participate... my skills in dancing will improve cause I'll have more practice... If I don't feel that sense of belonging, it's easier for other things to get in the way... (P07)

3.1.2 Future-oriented need.

Participants emphasized the importance of having deep connections to support future goals, such as engaging with individuals of higher economic status or being active in professional fields.

For some participants, fulfilling these needs didn't always require direct conversation. Sometimes just being visible in public settings could also impress others. They stated that being noticed could lead to potential future opportunities, as building a broader network is key for social rewards and long-term professional or personal benefits.

I believe it's when everyone, with a specific purpose in mind, goes to interact with the company's top executives. After these interactions, those individuals will follow up with some of the senior people they may have met that day, continuing the networking process, which becomes part of their job search. (P05)

3.1.3 Informational need.

For some participants, mingling events were more about seeking immediate rewards. Many aimed to exchange information, clarify misunderstandings, explore foreign cultures, or just leverage second language speaking skills.

Additionally, participation itself sometimes boosted confidence. The event served as a successful challenge that allowed participants to navigate unfamiliar settings and gain a sense of accomplishment.

3.1.4 Participation without a specific purpose.

Some participants deliberately avoided predefined goals, choosing to engage in a relaxed, authentic manner. They felt that specific intentions could make interactions seem forced, preferring a natural approach that allowed genuine connections without external pressures.

But as I mentioned earlier, I don't have any purpose. It's like if our frequencies don't match, it means we're not suited to be friends. And even if I get to know you, I'll still just lose the connection with you finally—so what's the point? (P01)

3.2 Difficulties in the mingling event

This section discusses the challenges participants face during the three key stages of mingling events: initial contact, maintaining communication, and forming deeper connections. Finally, it addresses the overall psychological pressure participants might have experienced throughout these interactions.

3.2.1 Hard to have initial contact.

Breaking the ice and establishing initial contact in mingling events can be a huge challenge, especially for people unfamiliar

with mingling culture. Unspoken norms often make these settings difficult to navigate without mingling experience.

You wouldn't, in Taiwan, just walk up to a group of strangers and say, "Can I join your discussion?" (P05)

Psychological barriers, such as fear of rejection, are rooted in past failures and further make the process more complicated. Personality traits like introversion can also make initiating contact or engaging with others more horrible.

Pre-existing social circles are "initial barriers," making it more difficult for newcomers to integrate. Perceived power distances, such as differences in social or professional status, also amplify these difficulties.

3.2.2 Hard to maintain the communication.

Maintaining meaningful conversations after initial contact is challenging for many participants. A lack of common ground can quickly freeze interactions. Language barriers complicate this, especially in multicultural settings where linguistic nuances differ. Cultural differences amplify these issues. It sometimes causes misunderstandings or discomfort, particularly when questions viewed as acceptable in one culture may feel rude in another.

Additionally, the fear of offending others and the implicit pressure to conform to social norms often make participants overly cautious. This leveraged focus on maintaining a favorable self-image can limit authentic communication.

3.2.3 Hard to have further contact.

Even when initial contact and conversations flow smoothly, forming deeper connections and maintaining relationships after the event often remain difficult for some participants.

Remembering details about people can also be challenging, especially in crowded or fast-paced mingling. Surface-level conversations reduce the chance to have deeper discussions, which are required to build stronger connections. Furthermore, without shared interests or contexts, many connections fade into fleeting and inconsequential encounters.

Everyone is like, "Ah, let's exchange Instagram handles". And it's like we're never going to talk again. We all know it. (P03)

3.2.4 Psychological pressure.

A lack of confidence often arises from previous failures, language barriers, or struggles to adapt to new environments. For some Asian students, this lack of confidence is heightened by the added stress of navigating job searches without a working visa, further intensifying discomfort in social settings.

Participants frequently worry about outcomes, fearing that failing to build connections is equal to personal failure. This anxiety, combined with a fear of awkwardness or social missteps, often hinders engagement.

3.3 Strategies used in the mingling events

3.3.1 Learning the Norm.

For newcomers, unfamiliar norms often shifted focus from conversations to conforming and thus added stress. Preparing conversation templates eased this anxiety, encouraging smoother integration. Beyond this, recognizing the freedom to casually approach or leave conversations is also viewed as essential.

Observing and mimicking experienced peers, such as Asian students who have stayed for several years, helped reduce uncertainty and align with expectations. Frequent participation further deepened their understanding of subtle norms, enabling more confident and seamless interactions.

3.3.2 Observing Strategically: Identifying Groups and Individuals for Effective Communication.

Careful observation is key to effective communication in mingling events. Participants often identify approachable groups or individuals beforehand, relying on subtle visual cues like clothing style, demeanor, or even the "level" of appearance in the event. These signals, while not definitive, indicate a higher likelihood of meaningful connections.

We are gay people, so like we've talked about how we gravitate to people who also look a bit gay, liberal, leftist... that kind of vibe. (P03)

Additionally, some participants sought support from "helpers" to ease social interactions. "Wingmen" reduced entry barriers by providing initial connections and introductions, while engaging with equally nervous individuals helped dispel the misconception that others were effortlessly confident, reducing social anxiety.

3.3.3 Identifying and Building Common Ground.

Establishing common ground is vital for effective mingling. Preparation helps lay the groundwork for connection. Staying informed about current events or potential shared knowledge areas provides useful topics to engage others.

Beyond content, subtler cues like matching speech pace are equally important. Aligned pacing eases communication, while mismatched pacing can create barriers.

For instance, I speak very quickly, and some people might find it hard to keep up with my pace, making it difficult for them to follow the conversation. (P01)

3.3.4 Creating a Sense of Approachability.

Creating a sense of approachability involves both passive and active strategies. Passively, self-restriction reduces the risk of being perceived as abnormal. Participants managed expressions in various ways, such as nodding or smiling without understanding or choosing neutral topics to avoid politics. Actively, providing friendly cues, like open body language and showing interest through questioning, creates a welcoming atmosphere.

If it's about a big city, something I shouldn't be unfamiliar with, I'll just smile and nod to get past it. (P02)

3.3.5 Creating Memorable Trait: The Key From Shallow Talk to Deeper Communication.

Creating memorable traits is key to transitioning from surface-level interactions to meaningful connections.

Perceived shared characteristics, such as visual cues or cultural markers, often establish immediate recognition in unfamiliar environments.

One of my friends from Madrid, he says that he went up to one of his closest friends because she had red hair, and like...it was like, Ok, we're going to be together. (P03)

At the same time, distinct backgrounds can become powerful conversation starters, transforming perceived disadvantages into unique strengths. Engaging with others who differ significantly

in age, ethnicity, or profession often sparks curiosity and leads to deeper dialogue.

The juxtaposition of seemingly contrasting traits also proved effective in making individuals memorable. The combination of unexpected elements adds complexity and stimulates a deeper exploration of shared and divergent experiences.

I think it's really cool. A rapper majors in marketing; it's really cool, right? (P05)

Finally, tailoring introductions further amplifies memorability, especially when cultural or linguistic nuances are considered. Playful associations, like puns or phonetic connections, resonate across different audiences and leave a lasting impression. For example, P05 creatively linked their name to a fruit with the same pronunciation in Chinese and to an easy-to-remember sentence in English.

4 Prototype design

Based on the insights presented in the previous chapter, the strategies used in the mingle event should not only maintain conversational flow but also create more chances for lasting connections.

Participants often took on strategies like learning norms or creating approachability, but these approaches did not effectively support their long-term needs, such as forming deeper connections or future opportunities.

Additionally, a repeated challenge mentioned was the difficulty in being remembered after the event. Participants also mentioned that noticeable visual characteristics or striking contrasts in characteristics often attract their attention.

The above findings show the importance of having distinct and memorable characteristics to create deeper connections.

4.1 Design goals

To deal with these challenges, we propose an LLM-supported tool aiming to help users identify and amplify their unique characteristics [6]. By externalizing thoughts and generating fresh perspectives, LLMs can encourage users to reflect on how they want to present themselves. However, fully relying on AI risks undermining user autonomy, which should also be considered in the design.

Therefore, our design goal is to empower participants to take ownership of their self-presentation while benefiting from AI support. Specifically, the system is designed to:

- (1) Assist users in uncovering overlooked or unexpected personal characteristics.
- (2) Reorganize and highlight these characteristics to make them more pronounced and engaging.
- (3) Provide visual cues to assist users in discovering which characteristics they genuinely wish to emphasize and making those traits naturally noticeable in mingling events.
- (4) Preserve user autonomy, ensuring that participants retain full control over how they define and showcase their characteristics.

4.2 Prototype Description

The prototype of the LLM-supported characteristics ideation tool includes three steps described in this session. Figure 1 shows the user interface of this tool.

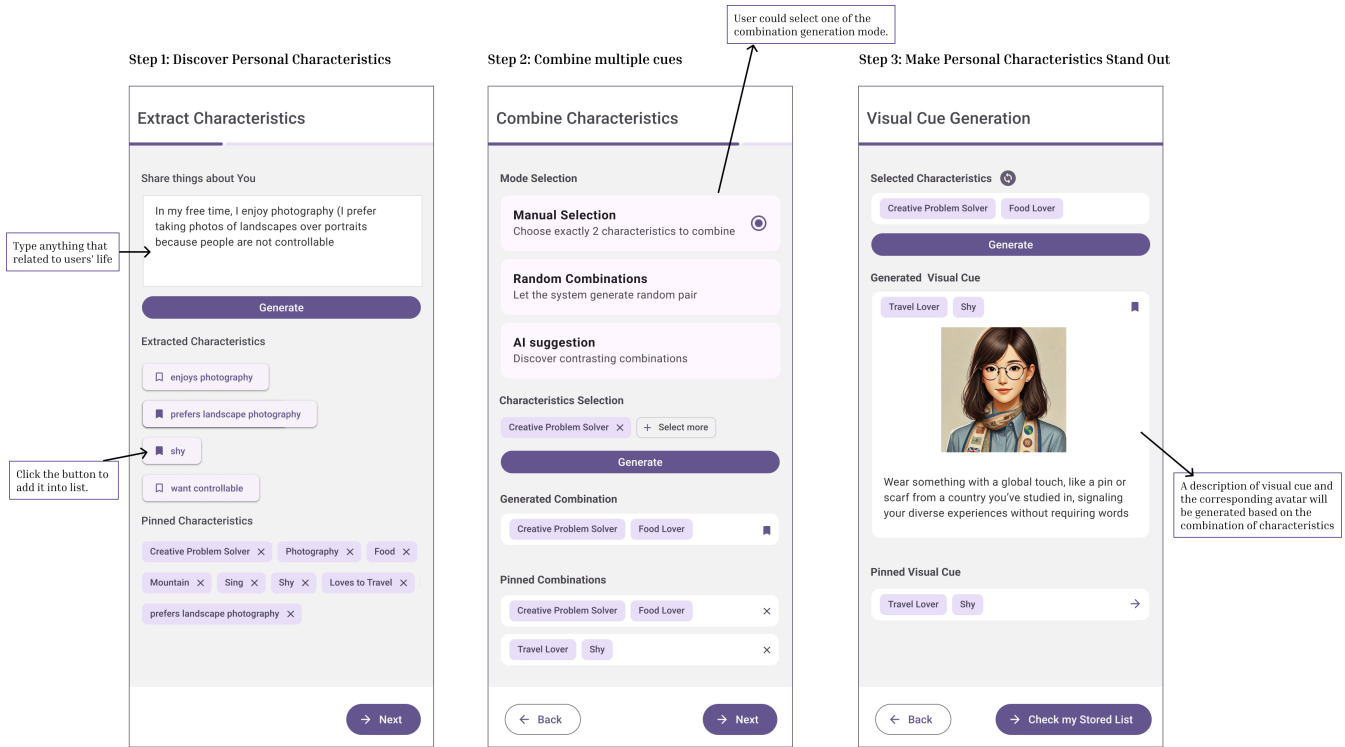


Figure 1: Prototype of the LLM-supported self-presentation ideation system

4.2.1 Step 1: Discovering Personal Characteristics.

The first step focuses on helping users explore and identify their unique traits, creating a foundation for confident self-expression.

- **Free Input Area:** Designed to reduce the barrier for self-expression, this intuitive input field allows users to freely type personal experiences, hobbies, or insights. By minimizing the constraints, it encourages users to engage thoughtfully with their unique qualities.
- **LLM-Suggested Characteristics:** Based on user input, the system generates multiple suggested potential standout characteristics. These serve as inspiration, helping users identify characteristics they might not have considered before.
- **Pinning Feature:** Users can pin preferable suggested characteristics, which are visually organized as tags at the bottom of the interface. This feature allows users to review and prioritize their discoveries for further refinement.

4.2.2 Step 2: Combining multiple cues.

In the second step, the system allows the user to combine the characteristics selected in the first in their preferred way. Users can experiment with different combinations of characteristics through three methods:

- **User-Selected Combinations:** Users manually select which characteristics to combine, allowing full control over the process.

- **System-Randomized Combinations:** The system randomly selects characteristics to pair, fostering serendipitous discoveries and unexpected alignments.
- **AI-Suggested Contrasting Combinations:** The system proposes combinations of characteristics that may seem initially incompatible, encouraging users to explore unique and creative identities.

4.2.3 Step 3: Making Personal Characteristics Stand Out.

In the last step, users could select one of the combinations from the previous steps. It includes:

- A descriptive **narrative of the proposed visual presentation**
- An **avatar with visual cues** that represents the suggested characteristics and cues

5 Limitations and Future Directions

A limitation of our current work is the relatively small number of participants and their limited diversity. Our study involved participants primarily recruited from a cross-cultural communication course in Taiwan. This recruitment strategy was intentional, as our work specifically addresses challenges faced by individuals from collectivist cultures—a group that may benefit the most from the proposed prototype due to the inherent cultural emphasis on group harmony and indirect communication. While this focus allows us to gain in-depth insights into the experiences of this target group, future researchers are encouraged to interview a broader pool of

participants from varied backgrounds to enrich the overall findings across different cultural contexts.

In the future, we plan to develop the proposed tool and conduct a user evaluation to refine our design, assess usability, and measure real-world impact. Our future work will focus on the following directions:

First, we will explore input behavior by investigating how users interact with the system and the type of content they provide. Given the current design's allowance for unrestricted input, we will use text analysis to identify common patterns and evaluate the potential benefits of a structured guide or manual. This will provide insights into enhancing input relevance and usability.

Second, user experience and usability will be assessed using established metrics, focusing on how effectively the system supports users in identifying and expressing their desired self-presentation. We will also analyze the role of visual representations in helping users select characteristics that align with their intended image. In this context, our research will address several key questions: Is the proposed tool more applicable for cross-cultural interactions compared to general social contexts? And are there specific aspects of cross-cultural mingling that make the tool more valuable compared to traditional techniques?

Third, we will examine the effectiveness of combination methods for personal characteristics, including user-selected combinations, random combinations, and AI-suggested contrasting combinations. By analyzing user preferences and perceived effectiveness, we aim to determine which approach best fosters creativity and supports self-expression.

Finally, to evaluate real-world applicability, we plan to adopt a diary study. This method will explore when and how users engage with the system, whether they integrate its suggestions into their self-presentation and their emotional responses to these changes. Specifically, we will assess if users adapt their appearance or provide additional visual cues based on the system's recommendations and how these adjustments influence their mingling experiences.

6 Conclusion

This paper investigates the challenges of cross-cultural mingling, focusing on how the strategies participants use during mingling often fail to align with their long-term purpose. Through interviews, we identify specific obstacles, including, but not limited to, language barriers, cultural norms that suppress self-promotion, and difficulties in standing out or being remembered. To address these gaps, we proposed an LLM-supported self-presentation ideation tool that enables users to identify, refine, and visually present their unique characteristics. This tool aims to help participants effectively navigate social interactions and achieve their personal objectives in mingling settings. Future research will assess the tool's usability and its impact on helping users meet long-term relationship-building goals.

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